Positive Discipline, From a Parent Who Used to Yell

October 4, 2026 · 3 min read

I want to start with an admission: I used to yell. Not occasionally. A lot. My daughter would do something, I'd feel this flash of anger, and before I could think, I was shouting. Then she'd cry, I'd feel terrible, and the whole cycle would repeat the next day. If that's where you are, I see you, and this post is for you.

The shift didn't come from a book, though I did read a couple. It came from noticing something. One day I yelled at my daughter for throwing her cup, and she flinched. Actually flinched. That image stuck with me in a way no parenting book ever had. I decided that night that I was going to change how I handled it, and I gave myself permission to be bad at it for a while.

Here's what I do now instead. It's not a system with a name. It's just a few habits.

First, I get down to her level before I say anything. Physically crouching down does something to my brain. It's hard to be towering and furious when you're at eye level with a small person. I can't explain it, but it buys me about five seconds, and five seconds is usually enough.

Second, I name what happened and what I need, short and plain. "You threw your cup. Cups stay on the table." That's it. No lecture. I used to follow up with a whole speech about respect and waste and how hard I work, and none of it ever landed. Kids tune out after about ten words. Say the ten words.

Third, I give her a way to fix it. "Pick up the cup, please." This was a game changer. Before, discipline was just me being upset at her. Now it ends with her doing something. It gives the whole interaction a landing spot instead of just dissolving into tears.

Fourth, consequences are related and immediate. She throws the cup, the cup goes away for the meal. Not "no TV tomorrow." Tomorrow is a different lifetime to a four-year-old. The consequence has to connect to the thing, and it has to happen now.

Now the honest part: I still yell sometimes. Maybe once every couple of weeks, when I'm tired and she's pushing every button I have. The difference is what happens after. I go back, I get down to her level, and I say, "I'm sorry I yelled. That wasn't okay. I was frustrated and I handled it badly." I used to think apologizing to my kid would undermine my authority. It did the opposite. She's started apologizing when she messes up, unprompted. Kids really do copy what you do, not what you say.

One more thing that helped more than I expected: I started noticing the good stuff out loud. "You shared with your brother without being asked, that was kind." It felt cheesy at first. But the behaviors I noticed started showing up more. Attention is like sunlight for kids. Point it at what you want to grow.

If you take one thing from this: you don't need to be a calm parent to start. You just need to be a parent who repairs. The apology matters more than the perfection.